Valentin Nikolaev

Backend Engineering Tech Lead

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LinkedIn | GitHub

Summary

Hands-on backend engineering leader with 15+ years of software development experience and five years of leadership across PHP and Go systems. Combines technical direction, architecture, planning, mentoring, and delivery ownership with direct contribution to production code. Experienced in guiding teams through product launches, cloud migrations, high-traffic events, and operational improvements while keeping reliability, maintainability, and business outcomes visible.

Leadership & Technical Skills

- **Leadership:** Technical Roadmaps, Architecture Decisions, Team Planning, Mentoring, Technical Interviews, Cross-Functional Collaboration
- **Backend:** Go, PHP, Laravel, Symfony, REST APIs, Microservices, Event-Driven Systems
- **Cloud & Delivery:** AWS, Kubernetes, Helm, CI/CD
- **Data & Reliability:** MySQL, PostgreSQL, RabbitMQ, Prometheus

Experience

Simple.life | Software Developer

November 2023 - August 2026

- Designed and owned a Go-based support automation platform connecting Zendesk, Intercom, and internal services.
- Translated operational needs into a unified API orchestration layer, automated triage workflows, and reliable message-delivery pipelines.
- Integrated flows that handled or deflected up to 30% of inbound tickets, helping the support organization scale automation coverage.
- Collaborated with Support Operations, Product, and engineering stakeholders while retaining end-to-end technical ownership of a business-critical platform.

Technologies: Go, REST APIs, Zendesk, Intercom, Monitoring, Backend Integrations

CRURATED | PHP Software Developer - Part-time Consulting Engagement

August 2024 - January 2026

- Architected and led development of an internal event analytics system supporting product metrics, reporting, and business insights.
- Established a versioned event schema and modular integration approach that accelerated new analytics streams from several days to under four hours.
- Designed fault-tolerant routing with retries, observability, delivery guarantees, and backpressure handling across multiple downstreams.

Technologies: PHP, Event-Driven Systems, Queues, AWS EventBridge, Webhooks, Amazon S3, Observability

airSlate | Senior Software Developer / Technical Lead

February 2021 - August 2023

- Supported Agile planning with Product Management and engineering, building feature roadmaps and release plans and owning team assignments through production delivery.
- Evaluated and distributed work across the team, tracked engineering performance, and contributed to an approximately 20% increase in feature delivery rate.
- Conducted more than 20 technical interviews and helped raise the technical bar through planning and delivery oversight.
- Remained hands-on with database and API optimization, ECS-to-Kubernetes migration, CI/CD, and production troubleshooting.

Technologies: PHP, Laravel, Symfony, MySQL, Elasticsearch, RabbitMQ, AWS, Kubernetes, Prometheus, Helm, GitHub Actions, ArgoCD

Hyprr | Technical Lead

November 2019 - January 2021

- Managed 10 developers and helped bring a creator-focused social and digital-asset platform from prototype to closed beta in under six months.
- Defined the technology roadmap with the CTO and influenced product planning, microservice and serverless architecture, CI/CD, reliability, and serviceability.
- Worked with business and technical stakeholders on product direction and remained directly involved in backend development.

Technologies: PHP, Go, Laravel, Mezzio, Phalcon, PostgreSQL, MySQL, AWS, Kubernetes, Microservices, REST APIs, Prometheus, Jaeger

PDFfiller | Software Developer / Backend Team Lead

October 2016 - November 2019

- Led five backend engineers developing a transactional email service that scaled to approximately 50 million messages per month.
- Made key technical decisions, coached engineers, and developed deep ownership of email-delivery infrastructure and production reliability.
- Guided the team through BFCM periods with more than 10x traffic growth while maintaining service continuity.

Technologies: PHP, Laravel, MySQL, Elasticsearch, RabbitMQ, AWS, REST APIs, Email Infrastructure, SRE

Education

MSc in Computer Science, National Technical University, Kharkiv, Ukraine | 2003 - 2008

Languages

- Ukrainian: Native
- English: Professional working proficiency / Upper-intermediate